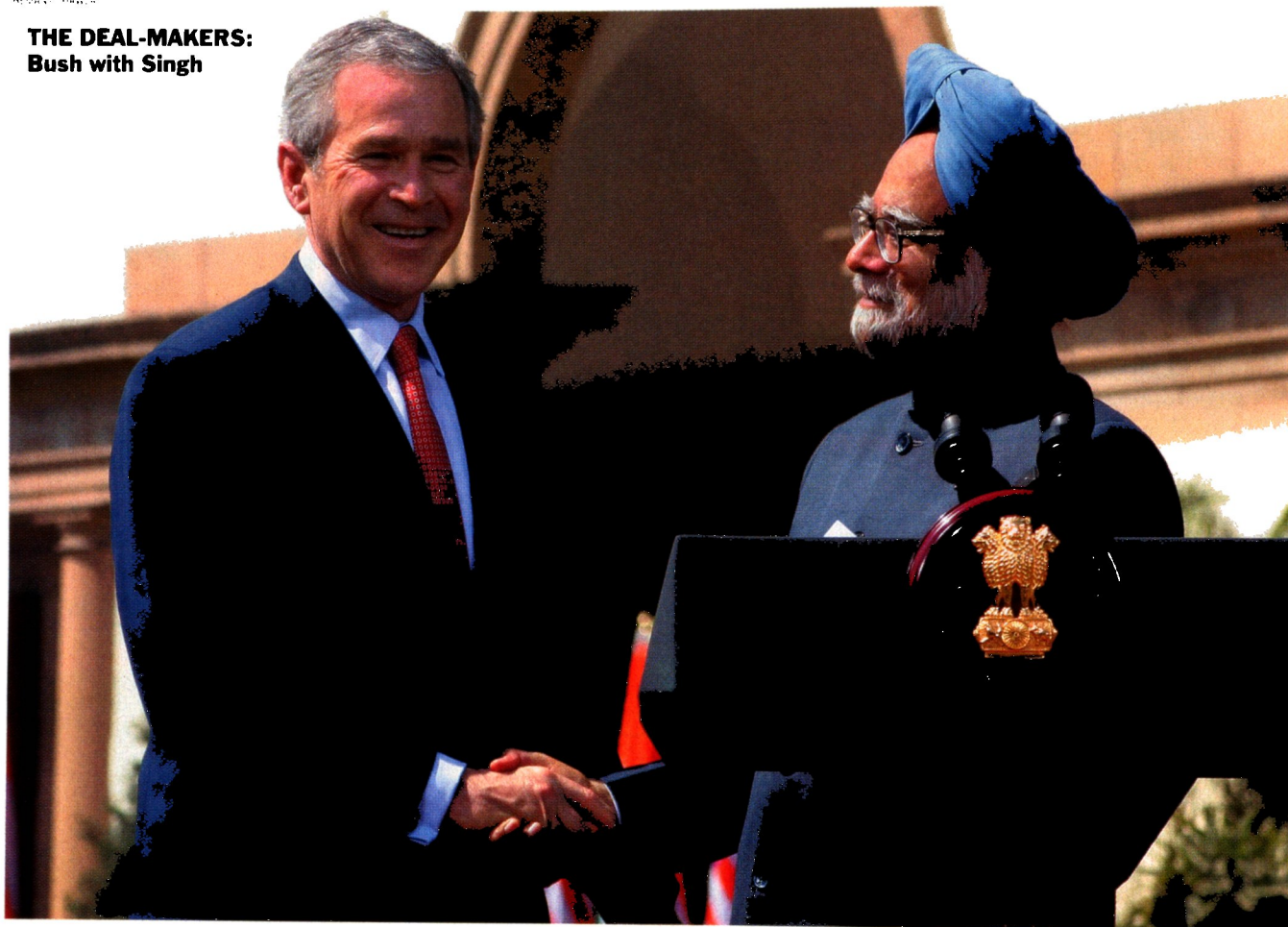


REMAKING INDIA

THE DEAL-MAKERS:
Bush with Singh



HOW THE DEAL WAS CLINCHED

THE INSIDE STORY OF HOW THE PRIME MINISTER DRIBBLED HIS WAY PAST THE OPPOSITION TO SECURE INDIA'S BIGGEST FOREIGN POLICY INITIATIVE IN THE RECENT YEARS

■ **By Raj Chengappa**

On the eve of India's 60th Independence Day, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh got a call from President George W. Bush congratulating the country on the occasion. Bush then went on to talk about how pleased he was that they had just crossed a major milestone on the Indo-US nuclear deal. Aware that Manmohan was getting hell for the deal from both his Left allies and the

Opposition parties, Bush said jocularly: "You have faced the music. Now back home, I have to face the music too."

For Bush too, although the US Congress is on vacation, criticism was coming in thick and fast from opponents of the deal. In the greatest of ironies, while Manmohan was being pilloried by his critics in India for "selling out to the US", Bush was being accused by his detractors of doing exactly the opposite: selling out to India. The US Arms Control Association, one of the leading non-proliferation lobbies, is-

sued a detailed memorandum titled, "A bad deal gets worse". Congressman Edward Markey got 23 bipartisan legislators to sign a statement that described the agreement as a "nuclear capitulation to India's every wish".

Given that the nuclear deal had already been hailed as the single most important initiative that India and the US have agreed to in the 60 years of their relationship, the storm of criticism did take both the leaders by surprise. It had taken two years and two days, nine rounds of negotiations and